

C203

Becoming an Effective Leader

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	------------------------	----------------------------------

Items

1.

A production supervisor at a 600-employee auto-parts plant sets clear daily targets, assigns each worker specific tasks and writes step-by-step procedures for changeovers. She joined the plant after eight years in the Navy. Which leader behavior from the Ohio State studies is she showing?

- A. Consideration.
- B. Initiating structure.
- C. Transformational leadership.
- D. Autocratic leadership, because of her military background.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A task-oriented (low-LPC) manager leads a well-liked team at a 25-year-old insurance firm. The team's work follows detailed, well-defined procedures, and she has strong authority to hire, reward and discipline. The firm recently switched office furniture suppliers. According to Fiedler, is she well matched to this situation?

- A. No; relationship-oriented leaders perform best in favorable situations.
- B. Yes; task-oriented leaders are always the better choice.
- C. No; she should adapt her style to be more relationship-oriented.
- D. Yes; task-oriented leaders perform best in very favorable situations.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Under Fiedler's contingency model, a leader's style does not match her situation. What does the model recommend?

- A. Train the leader to switch styles as needed.
- B. Nothing; a good leader succeeds in any situation.
- C. Wait for followers to adjust to the leader.
- D. Change the situation, such as task structure or position power, or move the leader to a better-fitting situation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

Claims processors at a health insurer handle repetitive, clearly defined work and say they feel stressed and bored. The team has a 97% accuracy rate, and the office moved to a hybrid schedule last year. According to path-goal theory, which leader behavior fits best?

- A. Directive leadership.
- B. Participative leadership, since it works for every team.
- C. Achievement-oriented leadership.
- D. Supportive leadership.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A senior software architect at a 1,500-person bank has no direct reports and no budget authority. Development teams still adopt her design standards, because they respect her deep knowledge of the bank's systems. She has worked there nine years. Which type of power is she using?

- A. Reward power.
- B. Legitimate power.
- C. Expert power.
- D. Referent power.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which situation is an example of referent power?

- A. A team follows a manager because she can approve their raises.
- B. Every manager has referent power automatically through the title.
- C. A team follows a manager because they admire her and want to be like her.
- D. A team follows a manager because she knows the system best.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

Posters at a marketing agency say “We value work-life balance.” The agency has 120 employees and a rooftop garden. Yet managers send emails at midnight, people who reply quickly get promoted, and everyone quietly believes that long hours prove commitment. In Schein's model, at what level is the belief that long hours prove commitment?

- A. Artifacts.
- B. Basic underlying assumptions.
- C. None; a company's culture is only what its official statements say.
- D. Espoused values.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which is an example of an artifact in Schein's model of culture?

- A. An open-plan office and a casual dress code.
- B. Unconscious beliefs about how people should be treated.
- C. The company's five-year strategic plan.
- D. The company's published statement of values.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A sales manager at a medical-supply firm with offices in four states gives three of her eight reps stretch assignments, early information about new accounts and freedom to make decisions. With the other five, she sticks to formal duties and required check-ins. The firm's revenue grew 9% last year. Which theory best describes her approach?

- A. Path-goal theory.
- B. Situational leadership.
- C. Leader-member exchange (in-group and out-group).
- D. Transformational leadership.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A hospital's director of nursing, who holds a doctorate and has published widely, opens every staff meeting by asking what her nurses need to do their jobs well. She puts their growth and well-being first and gives them credit for the unit's success. Which leadership approach does this reflect?

- A.** Authentic leadership.
- B.** Servant leadership.
- C.** Transactional leadership.
- D.** Laissez-faire leadership.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A top salesperson at a software company sets moderately difficult personal goals, wants frequent feedback on her numbers and likes to take personal responsibility for results. She won the company's sales award twice and drives a hybrid car. Which of McClelland's needs is strongest for her?

- A.** Need for achievement.
- B.** Need for affiliation.
- C.** Need for power, since all top performers are driven by power.
- D.** Need for power, because she wins awards.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

According to McClelland's research, which need profile is most typical of effective senior managers in large organizations?

- A.** High need for socialized power and relatively low need for affiliation.
- B.** Any profile works equally well in management.
- C.** High need for achievement and low need for power.
- D.** High need for affiliation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A production supervisor at a ~~600-employee~~ auto-parts plant sets clear daily targets, assigns each worker specific tasks and writes step-by-step procedures for changeovers. ~~She joined the plant after eight years in the Navy.~~ Which leader behavior from the Ohio State studies is she showing?

Target word: behavior dimension **Decides:** Defining tasks, targets and procedures.

A	Inverted operation	Consideration is the people-focused dimension.
B	Correct	Organizing work and defining roles is initiating structure.
C	Adjacent category	Transformational leadership inspires through vision, not procedures.
D	Camouflage	Answers the Navy detail; nothing says she excludes others from decisions.

2. Answer D Concept 2

A task-oriented (low-LPC) manager leads a well-liked team ~~at a 25-year-old insurance firm.~~ The team's work follows detailed, well-defined procedures, and she has strong authority to hire, reward and discipline. ~~The firm recently switched office furniture suppliers.~~ According to Fiedler, is she well matched to this situation?

Target word: match or mismatch **Decides:** Good relations, high task structure, strong position power: a very favorable situation.

A	Inverted operation	Relationship-oriented leaders do best in moderately favorable situations.
B	Absolute language	In moderate situations, relationship-oriented leaders do better.
C	Confusion set	That is situational leadership; Fiedler treats style as fixed.
D	Correct	Fiedler found low-LPC leaders excel at both extremes of favorability.

3. Answer D Concept 2 · transfer

Under Fiedler's contingency model, a leader's style does not match her situation. What does the model recommend?

Target word: fix for a mismatch **Decides:** Style is treated as fixed.

A	Confusion set	Style flexibility belongs to situational leadership, not Fiedler.
B	Absolute language	The model's core claim is that fit matters.
C	Dropped element	Drops the situational factors the model says to change.
D	Correct	Fiedler's remedy is to engineer the job or reassign the leader.

4. Answer D Concept 3

Claims processors at a health insurer handle repetitive, clearly defined work and say they feel stressed and bored. ~~The team has a 97% accuracy rate, and the office moved to a hybrid schedule last year.~~ According to path-goal theory, which leader behavior fits best?

Target word: best leader behavior **Decides:** Clear but tedious, stressful work.

A	Confusion set	The task is already clear; more direction adds nothing.
B	Absolute language	Path-goal theory matches behavior to conditions; no style fits all.
C	Adjacent category	Fits ambiguous, challenging work, not tedious routine.
D	Correct	Support offsets stress and boredom in routine work.

5. Answer C Concept 4

A senior software architect at a ~~1,500-person~~ bank has no direct reports and no budget authority. Development teams still adopt her design standards, because they respect her deep knowledge of the bank's systems. ~~She has worked there nine years.~~ Which type of power is she using?

Target word: power base **Decides:** Compliance comes from respect for her knowledge.

A	Adjacent category	She controls no budget or rewards.
B	Dropped element	Drops the fact that she has no formal authority.
C	Correct	Influence based on specialized knowledge.
D	Confusion set	Referent power comes from personal admiration, not expertise.

6. Answer C Concept 4 • transfer

Which situation is an example of referent power?

Target word: referent power **Decides:** Referent = admiration and identification.

A	Adjacent category	That is reward power.
B	Absolute language	Title gives legitimate power; referent power must be earned.
C	Correct	Personal attraction and identification is referent power.
D	Confusion set	That is expert power.

7. Answer B Concept 5

Posters at a marketing agency say “We value work-life balance.” ~~The agency has 120 employees and a rooftop garden.~~ Yet managers send emails at midnight, people who reply quickly get promoted, and everyone quietly believes that long hours prove commitment. In Schein's model, at what level is the belief that long hours prove commitment?

Target word: level of the belief **Decides:** It is unspoken and actually drives behavior.

A	Adjacent category	Artifacts are visible items such as posters or email timestamps, not beliefs.
B	Correct	Unspoken, taken-for-granted beliefs are the deepest level.
C	Absolute language	Schein shows real culture often differs from stated values.
D	Confusion set	The poster is the espoused value; the belief contradicts it.

8. Answer A Concept 5 • transfer

Which is an example of an artifact in Schein's model of culture?

Target word: an artifact **Decides:** Artifacts are visible and observable.

A	Correct	Visible structures and behaviors are artifacts.
B	Inverted operation	That is the deepest level, the opposite of visible artifacts.
C	Confusion set	Strategy is not one of Schein's culture levels.
D	Adjacent category	That is an espoused value.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A sales manager at a medical-supply firm ~~with offices in four states~~ gives three of her eight reps stretch assignments, early information about new accounts and freedom to make decisions. With the other five, she sticks to formal duties and required check-ins. ~~The firm's revenue grew 9% last year.~~ Which theory best describes her approach?

Target word: which theory **Decides:** Different relationship quality with different followers.

A	Confusion set	Path-goal matches behavior to task and follower needs, not in-groups.
B	Adjacent category	Situational leadership varies style by readiness on a task, not by relationship quality.
C	Correct	LMX describes high- and low-quality exchanges with different followers.
D	Inverted operation	Transformational leaders aim to raise all followers with a shared vision, not split them into groups.

10. Answer B Concept 7

A hospital's director of nursing, ~~who holds a doctorate and has published widely,~~ opens every staff meeting by asking what her nurses need to do their jobs well. She puts their growth and well-being first and gives them credit for the unit's success. Which leadership approach does this reflect?

Target word: leadership approach **Decides:** Followers' needs and growth come first.

A	Adjacent category	Authentic leadership centers on self-awareness and transparency.
B	Correct	Serving followers' needs and development is the core of servant leadership.
C	Inverted operation	Transactional leaders trade rewards for performance rather than serving followers.
D	Confusion set	Laissez-faire is hands-off; she is actively engaged.

11. Answer A Concept 8

A top salesperson at a software company sets moderately difficult personal goals, wants frequent feedback on her numbers and likes to take personal responsibility for results. ~~She won the company's sales award twice and drives a hybrid car.~~ Which of McClelland's needs is strongest for her?

Target word: dominant need **Decides:** Moderate goals, feedback, personal responsibility.

A	Correct	Those three preferences define high need for achievement.
B	Adjacent category	Affiliation centers on relationships and acceptance.
C	Absolute language	Power needs center on influencing others, not personal goals.
D	Camouflage	Answers the award detail; winning does not show a need to influence others.

12. Answer A Concept 8 • transfer

According to McClelland's research, which need profile is most typical of effective senior managers in large organizations?

Target word: effective manager profile **Decides:** Managers achieve through influencing others.

A	Correct	Influence used for the organization's goals, without needing to be liked, predicts managerial success.
B	Absolute language	McClelland found clear differences between profiles.
C	Inverted operation	That profile fits individual contributors; it flips what managers need.
D	Adjacent category	A strong need to be liked can make tough decisions harder.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	2	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	10	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	7	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	9	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	2	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Initiating structure vs. consideration	The Ohio State studies found two leader behaviors: initiating structure (defining roles, tasks and deadlines) and consideration (showing respect, trust and concern).	Calling any clear, firm leader transformational or autocratic.	A leader assigning tasks and setting procedures, or one attending to people's feelings.
2	Fiedler's contingency model	Leader style is fixed; task-oriented (low-LPC) leaders do best in very favorable or very unfavorable situations, relationship-oriented leaders in moderate ones; fix mismatches by changing the situation.	Telling the leader to adapt her style, as in situational leadership.	Leader-member relations, task structure and position power described together.
3	Path-goal theory	Leaders choose directive, supportive, participative or achievement-oriented behavior to fill what the task and followers lack; supportive fits stressful, tedious work.	Giving more direction on a task that is already clear.	A task described as routine, ambiguous or stressful, and followers' skills.
4	Bases of power	Legitimate = position; reward and coercive = control of outcomes; expert = knowledge; referent = admiration and identification.	Mixing up expert and referent power, or assuming all power comes from title.	Why people comply with someone, especially someone without formal authority.
5	Schein's levels of culture	Artifacts are visible; espoused values are stated; basic underlying assumptions are unspoken beliefs that actually drive behavior.	Taking stated values as the real culture.	A gap between what a company says and what people actually do.
6	Leader-member exchange	Leaders form high-quality (in-group) relationships with some followers, giving more trust, information and latitude, and formal (out-group) relationships with others.	Assuming a leader treats all followers the same way.	A leader giving some team members more access and opportunities.
7	Servant leadership	Servant leaders put followers' growth and well-being first and lead by serving their needs.	Confusing it with authentic leadership (self-awareness and transparency) or hands-off leadership.	A leader whose first question is what others need.
8	McClelland's acquired needs	Need for achievement drives personal excellence and feedback-seeking; need for affiliation drives relationships; need for (socialized) power drives influence and is common in effective senior managers.	Assuming the best individual performer will make the best manager.	A person's preferences for goals, feedback, relationships or influence.

Course scope (public description): This course explores major theories and approaches to leadership, leadership style evaluation, and personal leadership development while focusing on motivation, development, and achievement of others. You will learn how to influence followers, manage organizational culture, and enhance your effectiveness as a leader.